

enough to find a female emigrant to employ, the likelihood was that she would find a husband almost immediately and leave her position.

Servitude or slavery?

The lack of female workers led to initiatives to bring more working-class emigrants to Australia. In Britain, the government decided to provide incentives to encourage single, working-class women to emigrate. They offered women not only free passage but also money to get them started in their new lives abroad. Meanwhile, in famine-struck Ireland young women began to emigrate directly from the foundling hospitals and workhouses; some of these girls were as young as 15. At first, there was no infrastructure in place to help females find positions when they arrived,

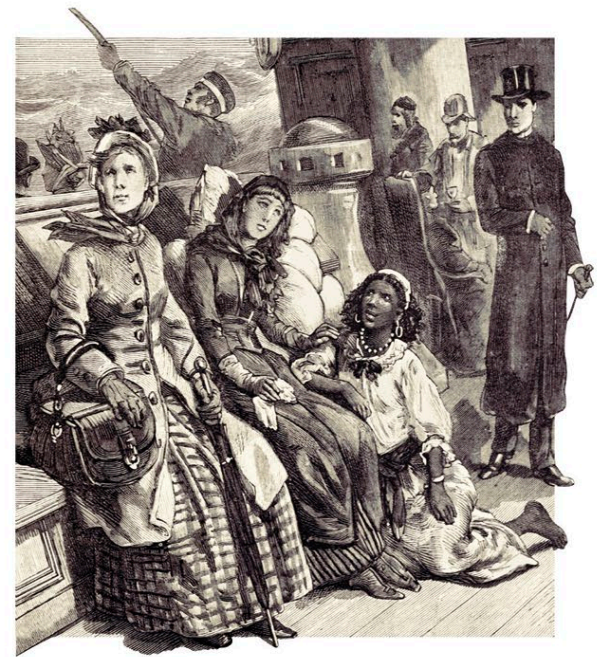
but in the 1840s, Caroline Chisholm began meeting every migrant ship that arrived in Sydney. She found domestic positions for many single girls, and in 1842 published her report *Female Immigration, Considered in a Brief Account of the Sydney Immigrants' Home*—the longest work published by any Australian woman up to that time.

In the 19th century, domestic service was the most common form of employment for Aboriginal women, and

the government came to believe that this was the only suitable employment for them.

Aboriginal servants were in great demand by European colonists. As a result girls who had been removed from their families were sent out from missions (see pp. 138–139) to work in households and look after children who were not much younger than themselves. Some historians regard this practice as akin to slavery: the youngest recorded Aboriginal servant girl in Queensland was only three years old. Aboriginal women and girls were expected to work incredibly hard, but were treated very poorly in return.

In the 20th century, domestic service in Australia became increasingly linked to the Aboriginal civil rights movement. In 1934, for example, a group of Aboriginal women who worked as domestics for white people petitioned the Royal Commission into Aboriginal Status and Conditions in Western Australia, asking that the commission “give us our Freedom and release us from the stigma of a native and make us happy Subjects of this our country.” However, even as late as the 1970s, young Aboriginal girls were separated from their families and forced into domestic work, and so were denied both the wages and education that might bring them freedom.



▲ Servitude

Two wealthy European women travel from England to Australia with their young Aboriginal servant seated on the ground beside them in this 19th-century illustration.

▼ Helping hand

The philanthropist Caroline Chisholm greets a newly arrived immigrant traveling with her child. Chisholm helped such women find work in Australia and established homes where they could stay.



**"THE BEST THING ... IS
TO SELECT SOME OLD
CRONE, NOT PAST WORK,
WHO IS VERY UGLY."**

CHARLES ROWCROFT, *TALES OF THE COLONIES*, 1843

